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(54) **BASEBALL TRAINING DEVICE FOR
PROPER STANCE**

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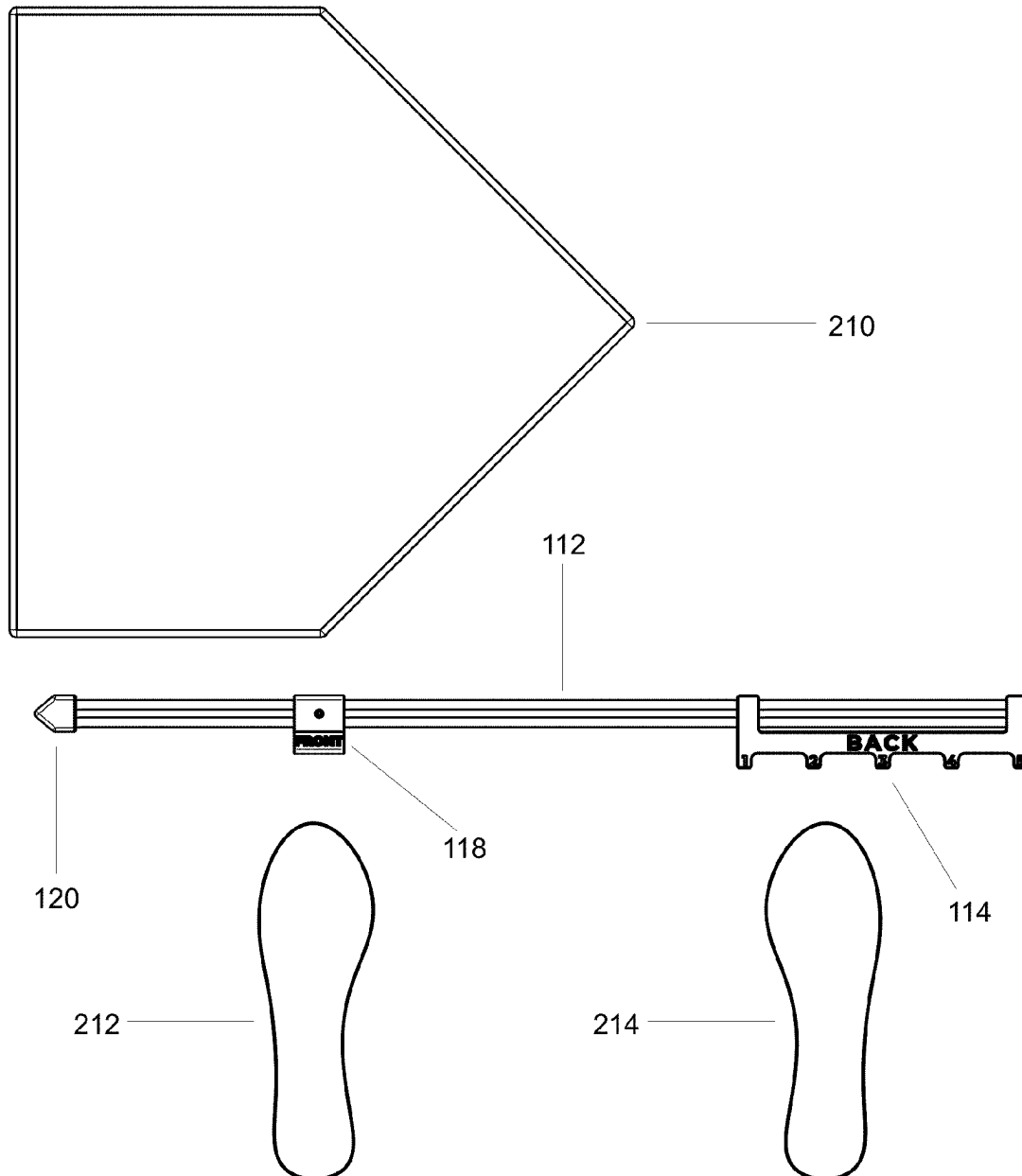
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ABSTRACT

A baseball stance training guide is disclosed, which comprises a back foot alignment component having a plurality of back foot alignment tabs, a front foot alignment component, and a direction-indicating component. This training guide provides quick visual indicators for young players that help them quickly and effectively identify where their back foot and front foot should be placed relative to home plate. The plurality of back foot alignment tabs provide an easy way for accommodating differences between players.



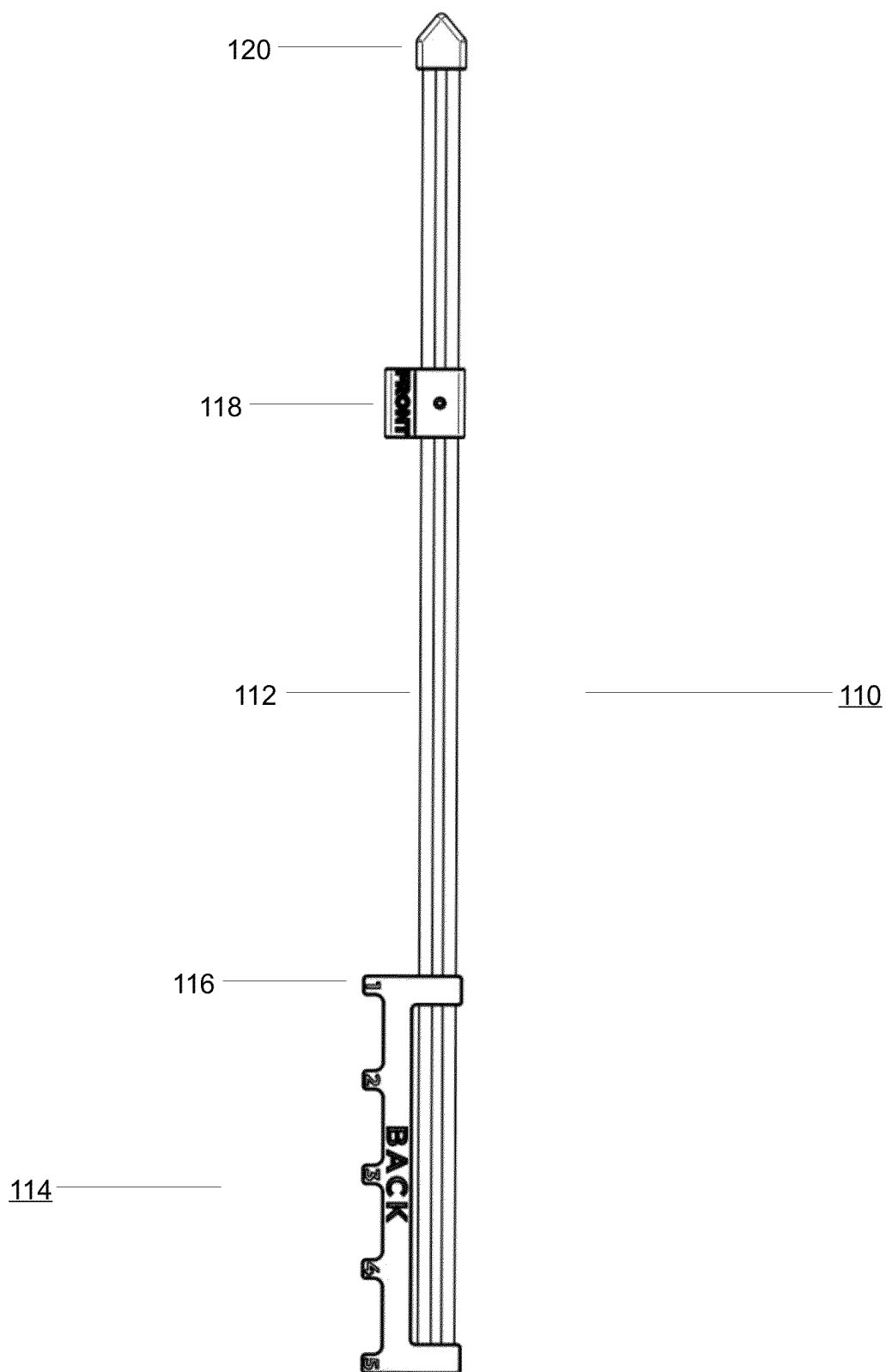


FIG. 1

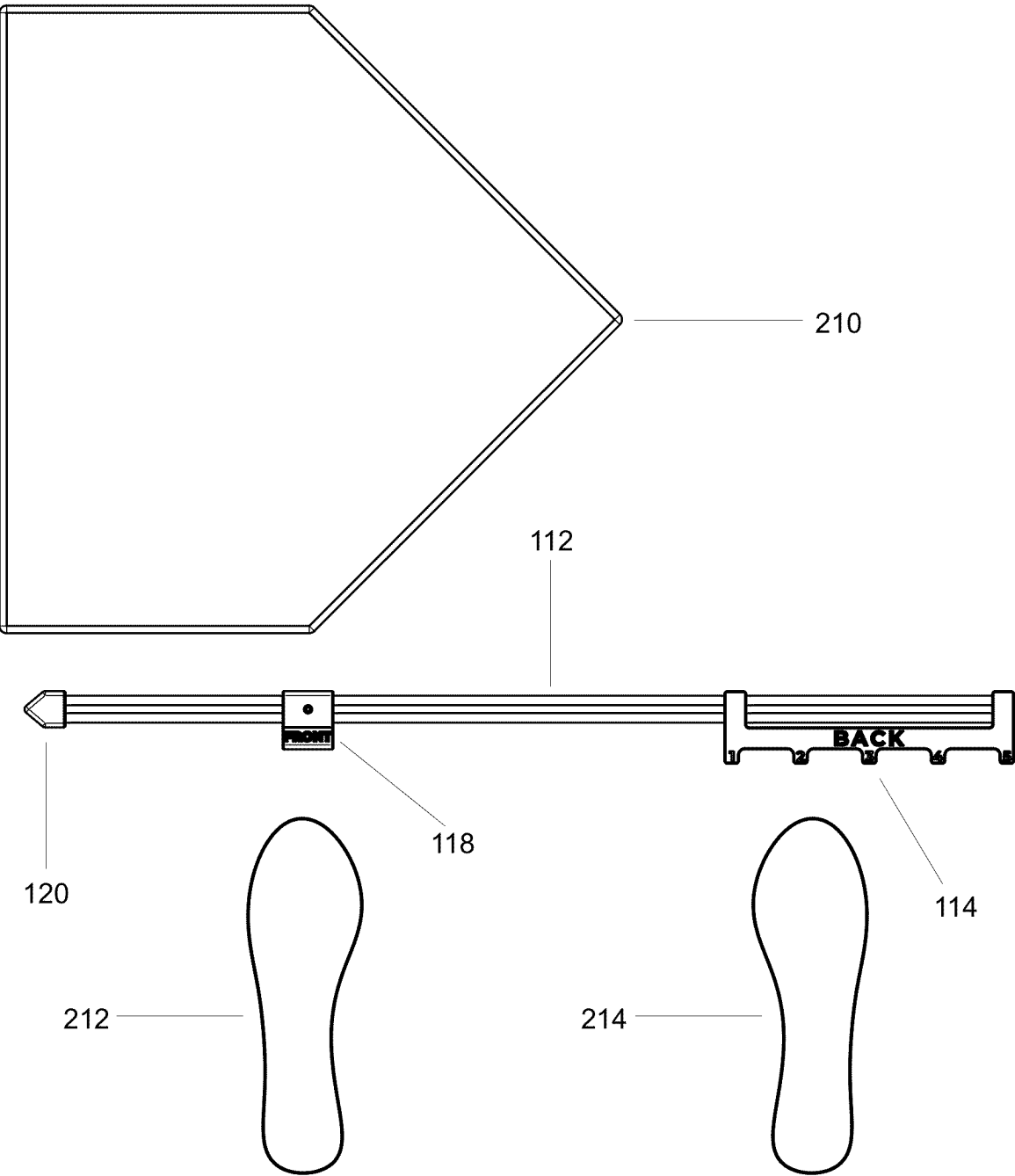


FIG. 2

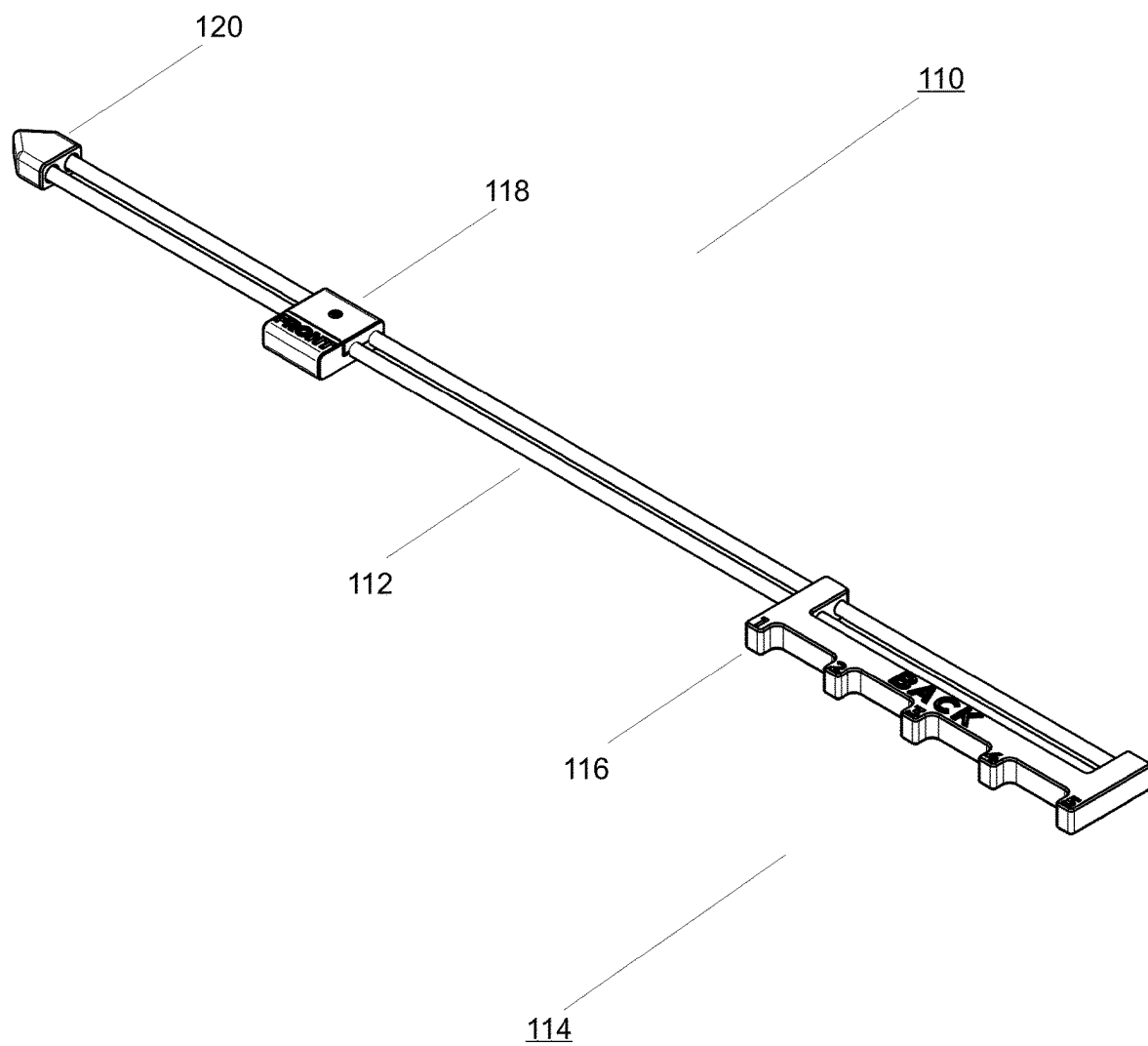


FIG. 3

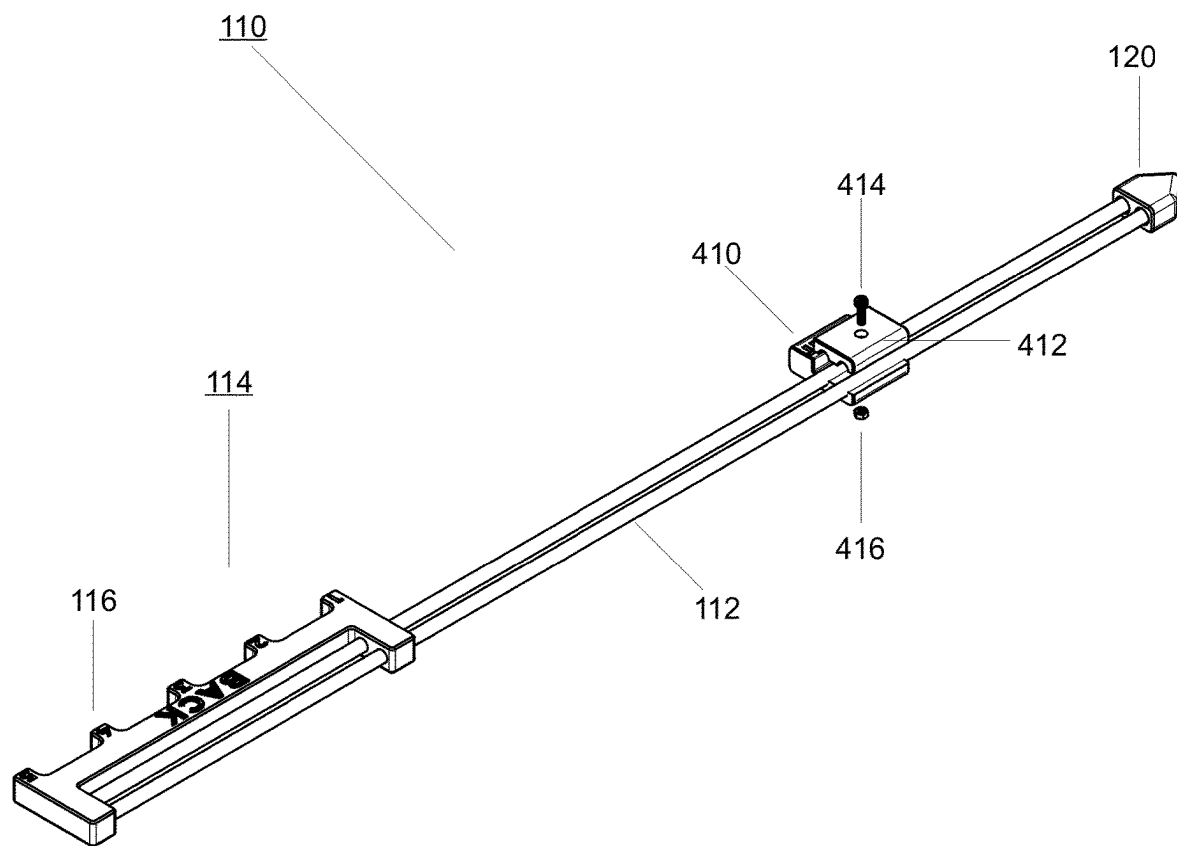


FIG. 4

BASEBALL TRAINING DEVICE FOR PROPER STANCE

STATEMENT REGARDING FEDERALLY SPONSORED RESEARCH OR DEVELOPMENT

[0001] Not applicable.

REFERENCE TO SEQUENCING LISTING, A TABLE, OR A COMPUTER PROGRAM LISTING COMPACT DISK APPENDIX

[0002] Not applicable.

BACKGROUND OF INVENTION

1. Field of Invention

[0003] The present invention relates to the field of baseball training aids. More specifically, this invention is in the field of baseball training aids for batting that are used for proper front and rear foot placement.

2. Description of Related Art

[0004] When teaching young children how to hit a baseball off of a tee, the focus is necessarily on the most fundamental aspects. This includes how a player's hands grip the bat, how far away from the tee a player stands, and where each foot not only starts but ends up during the swing. The present invention is geared specifically to promoting proper foot placement.

[0005] Regarding proper foot placement, it is important that a player consistently places his or her feet perpendicular to the near edge of home plate and the base of the tee (i.e. Toes pointing toward the near edge). It is also important that both feet are aligned with the pitcher's mound, especially at this learning stage. The front foot is also approximately aligned with the center of home plate. As such, the front foot is in line with the pitcher's mound in one direction and the center of home plate in a perpendicular direction. The back foot is spaced an appropriate distance from the front foot, but positioned along the same line established by the front foot and pitcher's mound (i.e. Back foot is parallel to and spaced about shoulder-width from the front foot).

[0006] Proper foot placement may seem easy enough, but for a young child lacking any familiarity with the game it takes consistent guidance from the coach. A coach may draw lines in the sand that indicate where the front foot and back foot should be placed. A coach may physically position a player's foot to a proper location only to have the other foot move out of position. While drawing lines in the sand can be very helpful, it must be done for each player since different players of differing heights and other characteristics usually need some adjustment regarding their foot placement.

[0007] While proper starting points for both the front foot and back foot are critical aspects, it is also important to teach young players to step toward the pitcher with the front foot to initiate the actual swinging of the bat. Certainly, placing another line in the sand can be helpful, but how far a player can or needs to step will vary significantly between players. Instead, it is more important to focus on teaching which foot steps forward and in what general direction.

[0008] A number of baseball training aids have been developed that are geared toward a player's batting stance and, in particular, the position of the player's feet. Some are adjustable, but a surprising number are very restrictive in

foot placement irrespective of each player's physical characteristics. Many of these aids are physically restrictive in other ways, too, such as not allowing rotation of the back foot or easily permitting stepping forward with the front foot to initiate the swing.

[0009] Another significant drawback of nearly all of these training aids is that a player must stand on top of the device. This necessarily limits a player's ability to engage with the ground during the swing. In fact, most players wear some form of cleat or soft-spiked shoe that are designed to positively engage with the ground. Introducing a foreign surface between a player's cleats and the dirt on the field does little to simulate the feel and reactionary forces involved in an actual swing. More so, as players who wear cleats on hard surfaces can attest, it is difficult to run or otherwise make sudden movements on such surfaces due to significantly reduced traction.

[0010] Patent U.S. Pat. No. 3,342,487 discloses a training device comprising a rectangular plate that a player stands on. The plate includes a guide for the front foot and a guide for the back foot, which place the feet generally perpendicular with the near edge of home plate. To initiate the swing, a player raises the front foot and strides forward, over the front foot guide to another set point. As discussed above, this training aid requires the player to stand on a rectangular plate, which does not simulate actual game conditions. Also, the design does not accommodate varying physical characteristics of each player. For instance, players' forward strides are noticeably different not only in elevation but distance going forward.

[0011] Patent U.S. Pat. No. 3,815,906 describes a batting stance guide that addresses some of these issues. Because the device is essentially an elevated frame, the player actually stands directly on the field. This better simulates real game conditions, at least so far as the players feet positively engaging with the ground. The training aid comprises a section for placing both the front foot and back foot, which establishes alignment with the pitcher's mound and the near edge of home plate. When the player initiates the swing, the player's front foot must step up and over a divider into a second section. By design, this training aid does accommodate varying physical characteristics between players. One drawback of this training aid, however, is that the divider does not allow much variation in a player's forward stride with his or her front foot. Some player's stride forward without significantly lifting the front foot off the ground. This device would be a hindrance to such players.

[0012] Patent U.S. Pat. No. 3,979,116 discloses a sheet material that a player stands on, which is demarcated to indicate where the player's front foot and back foot are to be placed. A dividing line on the sheet material, placed forward of the front foot, indicates where the player steps to initiate the swing. Essentially, the player's front foot begins in one section and, when the swing is initiated, steps over the dividing line and into a forward section. In contrast to U.S. Pat. No. 3,815,906, this training aid accommodates varying types of forward strides as well as other physical characteristics of each player. However, as with many of these training aids, this requires a player to stand on a foreign surface that does little to simulate real game conditions. U.S. Pat. Nos. 6,102,818 and 10,112,093 describe similar mats geared toward proper foot placement.

[0013] U.S. Pat. No. 5,330,176 is another mat or sheet similar in concept and is comprised of a numbered grid to

indicate where a player's feet should be at the start. These grids are numbered in a way that identifies not only how far the front foot and back foot are from one another but also how far both feet are from the tee. Arrows on the mat indicate the direction a player should step when initiating the swing. For example, a player may place his or her front foot on the Number 1 square and back foot on the Number 5 square. If a player is taller, it might be Number 15 for the front foot and Number 19 for back foot. With this training aid, each player would simply remember the appropriate numbers for his or her stance. The biggest downside of this training aid, however, is that a player must stand on top of it. Patent U.S. Pat. No. 5,536,004 discloses a very similar batting stance guide mat, but with a more simplified grid for variable foot placement.

[0014] The batting stance training aid disclosed in U.S. Pat. No. 4,516,772 comprises an elongated rail that is affixed with a front foot guide bar and a back foot guide bar. Either guide bar can be adjusted by sliding along the elongated rail so that each accommodates a given player. When the player initiates the swing, he or she must step over the front foot guide bar and toward the pitcher's mound. This training aid allows the player to make positive engagement with the actual ground and provides means for adjusting the guide bars to fit each player. While this training aid appears to function as intended, it will require manual adjustment for each player.

[0015] A teaching apparatus is described in U.S. Pat. No. 5,076,580 that comprises an attachment arm, which attaches to the base of the tee, and two dedicated foot pads spaced about shoulder-width apart. This training aid does not provide a means of adjustment to accommodate different players, however. While there is some adjustment allowed in terms of distance from the tee, the overall foot alignment with respect to the tee is not ideal as disclosed in this reference. Further, the attachment arm is not likely to accommodate the variety of tees available on the market. In fact, this training aid is excessively restrictive in many respects. Patents U.S. Pat. Nos. 5,947,833 and 9,492,727 are similarly-designed training aids.

[0016] Patent U.S. Pat. No. 6,926,625 discloses a rectangular frame having the dimensions similar to the batter's box often delineated for games with white chalk. There are three arms extending from the edge nearest home plate and extending toward the player who is positioned within the frame. Each arm is adjustable, which allows accommodation for various players, and each arm ends with a curved section indicating where a player's foot should rest. The rear arm indicates where the back foot is to be placed, the middle arm indicates where the front foot begins, and the front arm indicates where the front foot will end at the conclusion of the swing. This training aid is adjustable and allows a player to positively engage with the ground. Negative aspects of this training aid relate to its complexity and relative portability, however.

[0017] Each of these references were designed to address a fairly simple and straight-forward issue, namely ensuring that a player's feet are properly positioned relative to both home plate and the pitcher's mound. However, the majority of these training aids are much too complex for the intended goal, especially for young children. Further, many of these training aids do not simulate actual game conditions by requiring players stand on top of them.

[0018] In light of prior art, there remains a need for a batting stance guide that is simple to use, accommodates different players, and allows for a positive engagement with the ground. Such a guide must not only indicate where a player should place his or her front foot and back foot but also indicate in what direction the front foot should step to initiate the swing. Ideally, this batting stance guide should require little if any adjustment and serve mostly as a quick visual indicator of where a player's feet should be. For young children just learning the game, keeping it as simple as possible will go a long way to teaching them the fundamentals of foot placement.

BRIEF SUMMARY OF INVENTION

[0019] According to one embodiment, a baseball stance training guide used to promote proper foot placement comprises an elongated coupling member formed from a rigid material, a back foot alignment component, a front foot alignment component, and a direction-indicating component. The back foot alignment component is secured to one end of the elongated coupling member. The front foot alignment component is secured at a midpoint position along the elongated coupling member. The direction-indicating component is secured to an opposite end of the elongated coupling member. These components can be secured to the elongated coupling member using adhesive, mechanical fasteners like a screw and nut, or other suitable means.

[0020] The back foot alignment component, which comprises a plurality of back foot alignment tabs, is preferably labeled in a manner that designates it as being an alignment indicator for the back foot. In one embodiment, the back foot alignment component is labeled with the term "BACK" to designate it as the alignment component for the player's back foot. The back foot alignment component may also be color-coded or otherwise designated in a manner that informs the player that the back foot does not move during the swing. In one embodiment, the back foot alignment component may be red suggesting "stop", which is easily understood by young children.

[0021] The back foot alignment tabs serve as a visual indicator to each player, based on the player's specific characteristics, for the placement of his or her back foot. For instance, one player may have his or her back foot aligned with a back foot alignment tab designated with "1" while another player may align his or her foot with a back foot alignment tab designated with "3". This provides a simple and readily identifiable indicator of where to place the back foot.

[0022] The front foot alignment component is preferably labeled in a manner that designates it as being an alignment indicator for the front foot. In one embodiment, the front foot alignment component is labeled with the term "FRONT" to designate it as the indicator component for the player's front foot. The front foot alignment component may also be color-coded or otherwise designated in a manner that informs the player that the front foot is ready to step forward, toward the pitcher's mound. In one embodiment, the front foot indicator component may be yellow suggesting "ready" so as to encourage a young player that his or her front foot will initiate the swing.

[0023] The direction-indicating component is preferably designated in a manner that suggests it is an indicator of the general direction a player should step with his or her front foot to initiate the swing. For example, young children are

taught that “green means go” and that arrows indicate direction. In one embodiment, the direction-indicating component is a green arrow to indicate not only the direction but also an active step to initiate the swing.

[0024] The baseball stance training guide is placed on the ground immediately adjacent to home plate and parallel to the near edge of home plate. It is preferred that the front foot alignment component is aligned with the stem of the tee or center of home plate. A player approaches the tee and t-ball training device, aligning his or her front foot with the front foot alignment component and his or her back foot with the specific back foot alignment tab appropriate for the player. The player's feet are now in alignment with the pitcher's mound and appropriately spaced. The upward facing alignment indicators for each component (e.g. “FRONT”) and the back foot alignment tab numerals are present on either side of the respective components. In this way, the baseball stance training guide is simply flipped over and moved to opposite side of home plate for a left-handed batter, for example.

[0025] A suitable distance from home plate and the tee depends on a number of factors, such as length of a player's arms, length of a player's bat, and whether a player has a compact or elongated swing. An initial step to adjust this distance involves extension of the player's arms and bat toward the ball, identification of the “sweet spot” on the bat, and movement of the feet toward or away from the tee in order to match the sweet spot of the bat with the ball while arms are extended.

[0026] With the feet spaced appropriately, in terms of both alignment with the pitcher's mound and tee and distance from home plate and the tee, the player is ready to initiate the swing. A player initiates the swing by stepping forward with his or her front foot, in the direction indicated by the direction-indicating component. In this way, the baseball stance training guide described herein simply and effectively serves as a visual indicator for young players, indicating proper foot placement from start to finish.

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF DRAWINGS

[0027] FIG. 1 is a top view of one embodiment of a baseball stance training guide;

[0028] FIG. 2 is a top view of one embodiment of a baseball stance training guide demonstrating a preferred alignment with home plate and exemplifying front foot and back foot placement relative to the training guide;

[0029] FIG. 3 is a perspective view of an embodiment of a baseball stance training guide; and

[0030] FIG. 4 is an exploded perspective view illustrating one manner of securing a front foot alignment component to an elongated coupling member formed from a rigid material.

REFERENCE NUMERALS FOR DRAWINGS

(Please note that the first digit indicates the figure in which a component is first readily identifiable)

- [0031]** 110 Baseball stance training guide
- [0032]** 112 Elongated coupling member
- [0033]** 114 Back foot alignment component
- [0034]** 116 Back foot alignment tabs
- [0035]** 118 Front foot alignment component
- [0036]** 120 Direction-indicating component
- [0037]** 210 Home plate
- [0038]** 212 Batter's front foot

- [0039]** 214 Batter's back foot
- [0040]** 410 Front foot alignment component base
- [0041]** 412 Front foot alignment component clamp
- [0042]** 414 Clamp screw
- [0043]** 416 Base nut

DETAILED DESCRIPTION OF DRAWINGS

[0044] FIG. 1 illustrates a top view of one embodiment of a baseball stance training guide 110. The baseball stance training guide 110 comprises at least one elongated coupling member 112 formed from a rigid material, a back foot alignment component 114, a front foot alignment component 118, and a direction-indicating component 120. The back foot alignment component 114 further comprises a plurality of back foot alignment tabs 116.

[0045] The back foot alignment component 114 is secured at one end of at least one elongated coupling member 112 and the direction-indicating component 120 is secured to an opposite end of at least one elongated coupling member 112. The front foot alignment component 118 is secured to a midpoint of at least one elongated coupling member 112.

[0046] FIG. 2 is another top view illustrating a baseball stance training guide 110 and its intended use. The baseball stance training guide 110 is aligned with an edge of a home plate 210. As an example, the view illustrates a right-handed batter's front foot 212 and back foot 214 placement relative to the baseball stance training guide 110.

[0047] FIG. 3 is a perspective view of one embodiment of a baseball stance training guide 110. This view indicates components depicted in FIG. 1, such as at least one elongated coupling member 112, a back foot alignment component 114, a front foot alignment component 118, and a direction-indicating component 120. The back foot alignment component 114 further comprises a plurality of back foot alignment tabs 116.

[0048] FIG. 4 is an exploded perspective view of one embodiment of a baseball stance training guide 110. This view identifies one manner of securing the front foot alignment component 118 to at least one elongated coupling member 112. In this embodiment, the front foot alignment component 118 comprises a front foot alignment component base 410, a front foot alignment component clamp 412, a clamp screw 414, and a base nut 416. At least one elongated coupling member 112 is clamped to the front foot alignment component base 410 by compressive forces of the front foot alignment component clamp 412 and associated clamp screw 414 and base nut 416.

[0049] While specific embodiments and applications of the present invention have been described herein, it will be apparent to those of ordinary skill in the art that many variations on the embodiments and applications described are possible without departing from the scope of the invention. It should be understood that while certain embodiments of the invention have been shown and described, the invention is not to be limited to the specific embodiments described and illustrated.

The invention claimed is:

1. A baseball stance training guide used to promote proper foot placement, comprising:
 - a back foot alignment component comprising a plurality of back foot alignment tabs;
 - a front foot alignment component;
 - a direction-indicating component; and

at least one elongated coupling member formed from a rigid material, said back foot alignment component attached to a first end of said at least one elongated coupling member, said direction-indicating component attached to an opposite end of said at least one elongated coupling member, said front foot alignment component attached at a midpoint of said at least one elongated coupling member;

whereby said back foot alignment component is positioned at the end of said elongated coupling member to indicate back foot placement, said front foot alignment component is positioned at the midpoint of said at least one elongated coupling member to indicate front foot placement, and said direction-indicating component is positioned at the opposite end of said elongated coupling member to indicate a direction a user steps to initiate a swing.

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